

# Existentialism — Answer-Writing Toolkit and Solved PYQ Workbook

**Sixteen verified PYQs and nine original solved models**

All model answers are independent learner-practice answers, never official UPSC answer keys.

# CONTENTS

Page numbers are generated from the final layout. PDF bookmarks include finer subheadings.

|                                 |    |                                   |    |
|---------------------------------|----|-----------------------------------|----|
| Ownership and demand map        | 3  | 13. 2024 Q4(a) · 20 marks         | 25 |
| Reusable answer-writing toolkit | 4  | 14. 2025 Q1(c) · 10 marks         | 27 |
| Fully solved verified PYQs      | 5  | 15. 2026 Q2(c) · 15 marks         | 28 |
| 1. 2018 Q1(d) · 10 marks        | 5  | 16. 2026 Q3(b) · 15 marks         | 29 |
| 2. 2018 Q4(a) · 20 marks        | 7  | Original 1 · 10 marks             | 31 |
| 3. 2019 Q3(a) · 20 marks        | 8  | Original 2 · 15 marks             | 31 |
| 4. 2019 Q4(c) · 15 marks        | 10 | Original 3 · 20 marks             | 32 |
| 5. 2020 Q3(a) · 20 marks        | 12 | Original 4 · 10 marks             | 33 |
| 6. 2020 Q4(a) · 20 marks        | 14 | Original 5 · 10 marks             | 34 |
| 7. 2021 Q4(b) · 15 marks        | 15 | Original 6 · 15 marks             | 35 |
| 8. 2022 Q2(a) · 20 marks        | 17 | Original 7 · 15 marks             | 36 |
| 9. 2022 Q4(a) · 20 marks        | 19 | Original 8 · 20 marks             | 36 |
| 10. 2023 Q1(d) · 10 marks       | 20 | Original 9 · 20 marks             | 38 |
| 11. 2023 Q3(c) · 15 marks       | 22 | Self-evaluation grid              | 39 |
| 12. 2024 Q1(e) · 10 marks       | 23 | Inbound obligations from Topic 09 | 39 |

## Ownership and demand map

Topic 10 directly owns **16 verified PYQ parts through 2026**: fourteen from 2018–2025 and two from 2026. The 2018 epoché limb is attributed to Husserl but remains primarily owned here because Heidegger's rejection and being-in-the-world carry the question. The 2026 Sartre–Husserl comparison is primary-owned here; Topic 09 holds only the bounded Husserl cross-link.

| Year | Part  | Marks | Primary demand                                                                                                               |
|------|-------|-------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2018 | Q1(d) | 10    | connect inauthenticity and bad faith; explain alienation; use facticity and transcendence; qualify through social constraint |
| 2018 | Q4(a) | 20    | define Husserlian epoché; explain Heidegger's rejection; develop being-in-the-world; contrast transcendental ego             |
| 2019 | Q3(a) | 20    | correct the premise about Dasein; explain authenticity; relate Care and temporality; evaluate the unfinished project         |
| 2019 | Q4(c) | 15    | state the freedom thesis; explain meaning-conferral; distinguish situation from determinism; give a qualified verdict        |
| 2020 | Q3(a) | 20    | define subjective truth; connect the single individual; guard against relativism; assess the anti-system claim               |
| 2020 | Q4(a) | 20    | decode facticity and transcendence; explain situated freedom; press structural objections; grade the quotation               |
| 2021 | Q4(b) | 15    | explain non-choice as choice; derive responsibility; connect universal implication; qualify coercion and constraint          |
| 2022 | Q2(a) | 20    | explain unitary being-in-the-world; develop worldhood and Care; explain authenticity; evaluate formal emptiness              |
| 2022 | Q4(a) | 20    | define subjectivity; explain three stages; show qualitative transition; evaluate faith and reason                            |

| Year | Part  | Marks | Primary demand                                                                                                                 |
|------|-------|-------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2023 | Q1(d) | 10    | state Hegelian target; defend the existing individual; show structural contrasts; qualify the critique                         |
| 2023 | Q3(c) | 15    | unpack both clauses; explain nihilation; derive freedom and bad faith; assess coherence                                        |
| 2024 | Q1(e) | 10    | define the how of appropriation; distinguish objective truth; name Climacus; evaluate fideism                                  |
| 2024 | Q4(a) | 20    | explain Sartre's slogan; differentiate the three thinkers; connect existence and freedom; assess responsibility and value      |
| 2025 | Q1(c) | 10    | define en-soi; define pour-soi; explain nihilation; state the impossible synthesis                                             |
| 2026 | Q2(c) | 15    | describe consciousness as nothing; state shared intentionality; contrast the ego and constitution; give a qualified comparison |
| 2026 | Q3(b) | 15    | define both modes; explain das Man and falling; explain resoluteness and death; preserve the non-moral boundary                |

## Reusable answer-writing toolkit

### Introductions

- **Family opener:** Existentialism is a family of distinct projects united by attention to concrete finite existence but divided over God, freedom and Being.
- **Kierkegaard opener:** Kierkegaard relocates truth from possession of a system to the existing individual's passionate appropriation.
- **Sartre opener:** Sartre grounds human reality in the non-self-identity of consciousness, from which freedom, bad faith and responsibility follow.
- **Heidegger opener:** Heidegger's analytic of Dasein serves fundamental ontology; authenticity and temporality are modes of finite being-in-the-world.

### High-value analytical lines

- The slogan is Sartre's, the anti-system impulse is Kierkegaard's, and the ontological recasting is Heidegger's.

- Facticity constrains the field; transcendence concerns how the field is taken up.
- Heideggerian authenticity supplies a form of ownedness rather than a moral content.
- Sartre's nothingness is a lack of thing-like self-identity, not the nonexistence of consciousness.
- Anxiety is privileged because its objectlessness discloses a structure rather than one threatening entity.

## Diagram bank

KIERKEGAARD: aesthetic --leap--> ethical --leap--> religious  
 SARTRE: facticity <---- human reality ----> transcendence  
 HEIDEGGER: ahead-of-itself + already-in + alongside = CARE  
 TEMPORALITY: future/projection + having-been/throwness + present/involvement

## Time and word guidance

| Marks | Planning | Writing | Revision | Target words |
|-------|----------|---------|----------|--------------|
| 10    | 1 min    | 6 min   | 1 min    | 150–200      |
| 15    | 2 min    | 9 min   | 1 min    | 250–300      |
| 20    | 3 min    | 13 min  | 2 min    | 340–400      |

## Fully solved verified PYQs

### 1. 2018 Q1(d) · 10 marks

**Question:** How does Sartre connect inauthenticity with bad faith? Why does Sartre show that inauthenticity and bad faith lead to alienation? Discuss.

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2018 repository ledger.

**Demand decoding:** - connect inauthenticity and bad faith. - explain alienation. - use facticity and transcendence. - qualify through social constraint.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 150–200 words in about 8 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

### Timed independent model answer

For Sartre, inauthenticity is the settled way of living in bad faith. Human reality combines facticity—body, past, role and situation—with transcendence, the freedom to surpass what is given. Bad faith denies this unstable unity by treating oneself either as pure facticity, like the waiter who acts as though he simply is his role, or as pure transcendence, like the woman who detaches her hand from the meaning of the encounter.

Alienation follows because consciousness then lives through an identity it has made foreign to its own freedom. Under the Other's Look, it also encounters itself as an object whose meaning is fixed from outside. Inauthenticity is therefore the enduring stance, bad faith its mechanism, and alienation its result.

The account powerfully explains self-deception without positing a separate unconscious censor. Its limit is social: oppression can impose roles and restrict possibilities rather than merely tempt a free subject to evade responsibility. Sartre's later idea of situated freedom partly answers this objection, but the theory remains strongest as an account of self-alienation, not a complete social theory of alienation.

**Measured model-answer words:** 179

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine's exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

**Expanded repair notes:**

**Thesis.** For Sartre inauthenticity *is* the settled practice of bad faith, and bad faith produces alienation because it makes consciousness live as the object it pretends to be - so the three terms name one downward movement, not three separate facts.

**Doctrine and evidence.** Every human reality has two dimensions: **facticity** (*facticite* - body, past, role, situation) and **transcendence** (freedom to surpass the given). **Bad faith** (*mauvaise foi*) is the project of collapsing the two - identifying with facticity *alone* (the waiter who so perfectly "is" a waiter that he forgets he is free to quit) or with transcendence *alone* (the woman on the date who treats her captured hand as a mere thing). This is possible because the *pour-soi* "is what it is not and is not what it is": consciousness is non-self-identical, so it can hold a truth and its denial in one pre-reflective stance, with no Freudian unconscious required. **Inauthenticity** is bad faith made habitual: consciousness chronically denies its own unstable freedom.

**Analysis - how alienation follows.** Alienation is the terminus. Living through fixed social roles or, above all, under the objectifying **Look** (*le regard*), the self comes to exist *as the object the Other sees* - it acquires "an outside" it did not choose and cannot control. In fleeing the anguish of freedom into role and role-into-thing, consciousness estranges itself from its own transcendence: it is present to itself as an alien object. Thus inauthenticity (the stance) -> bad faith (its mechanism) -> alienation (its result).

**Objection and reply.** Critics (the Marxist tradition, Merleau-Ponty) object that this psychologises alienation and ignores the *structural* oppression that genuinely limits people. Sartre's reply is situated freedom - one always chooses *from* a factual situation, never from nowhere - and his later *Critique of Dialectical Reason* (1960) concedes scarcity, seriality and the practico-inert far more than *Being and Nothingness* (1943) did.

**Verdict.** Bad faith is one of Sartre's most influential concepts because it explains self-deception without splitting the self; its limit is normative - if all consciousness is non-self-identical, what finally distinguishes bad faith from ordinary living? The promised ethics of authenticity was gestured at in a footnote and never written.

## 2. 2018 Q4(a) · 20 marks

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**Question:** What is 'Epoché'? How does Heidegger reject this method of phenomenological reduction? Explain Heidegger's concept of 'being in the world' as opposed to the concept of a transcendental ego.

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2018 repository ledger.

**Demand decoding:** - define Husserlian epoché. - explain Heidegger's rejection. - develop being-in-the-world. - contrast transcendental ego.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 340–400 words in about 18 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

### Timed independent model answer

*Epoche* is **Husserl's** device, not Heidegger's; Heidegger rejects it because the reduction presupposes exactly what is most questionable - a worldless spectator-subject - whereas the primordial fact is Dasein's always-already **being-in-the-world**. (Ownership note: this part belongs to Existentialism because its burden is Heidegger's alternative; *Epoche* itself is attributed to Husserl and kept separate from the Phenomenology topic.)

In Husserl the **epoche** (bracketing, *Einklammerung*) suspends the "general thesis" of the natural attitude - the standing posit that the world exists independently - so that consciousness can be described purely as it gives itself. The **phenomenological reduction** then leads back (*re-ducere*) to the **transcendental ego**, the constituting field *for which* the world has sense. Husserl's is thus a philosophy that begins by *withholding the world*.

Heidegger's objection is that this starting point is already an abstraction. To bracket the world and retreat to a transcendental ego is to assume that consciousness *could* be world-less - the very Cartesian picture (subject inside, world outside) that must be overcome. The more primordial condition is that Dasein is *always already* absorbed, concerned, involved: subject and object are *derivative* precipitates of practical involvement, not the bedrock. One cannot "bracket" the world because one is never outside it.

"Being-in-the-world" (*In-der-Welt-sein*) is **one unitary phenomenon** - the hyphens are the doctrine; it resists decomposition into subject + relation + object. Its evidence is the analysis of **equipment**: a hammer is first met as **ready-to-hand** (*Zuhandenheit*), absorbed in an "in-order-to" web (nail-board-house-dwelling), the *worldhood* of the world. Only when it **breaks** does the bare **present-at-hand** (*Vorhandenheit*) object of theoretical staring appear - so the detached ego of theory is a *founded*, deficient mode, not the origin. Against Husserl's constituting ego stands Dasein's thrown, practical disclosedness (*Befindlichkeit*, *Verstehen*, *Rede*), unified as **Care** (*Sorge*).

Husserlians reply that Heidegger has merely relocated, not answered, the constitution question, and that description still needs *some* methodological purification. But the decisive point stands: if the subject is always already worldly, the reduction cannot reach a presuppositionless residue. Provenance discipline: cite *Being and Time* (1927) by section (worldhood ss.15-18, Care s.41); the work is **unfinished** - never say it "completes" the analysis of Being.

**Measured model-answer words:** 350

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine's exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

**Expanded repair notes:**

**Thesis.** *Epoche* is **Husserl's** device, not Heidegger's; Heidegger rejects it because the reduction presupposes exactly what is most questionable - a worldless spectator-subject - whereas the primordial fact is Dasein's always-already **being-in-the-world**. (Ownership note: this part belongs to Existentialism because its burden is Heidegger's alternative; *Epoche* itself is attributed to Husserl and kept separate from the Phenomenology topic.)

**What Epoche is (attributed correctly).** In Husserl the **epoche** (bracketing, *Einklammerung*) suspends the "general thesis" of the natural attitude - the standing posit that the world exists independently - so that consciousness can be described purely as it gives itself. The **phenomenological reduction** then leads back (*re-ducere*) to the **transcendental ego**, the constituting field *for which* the world has sense. Husserl's is thus a philosophy that begins by *withholding the world*.

**Heidegger's rejection.** Heidegger's objection is that this starting point is already an abstraction. To bracket the world and retreat to a transcendental ego is to assume that consciousness *could* be world-less - the very Cartesian picture (subject inside, world outside) that must be overcome. The more primordial condition is that Dasein is *always already* absorbed, concerned, involved: subject and object are *derivative* precipitates of practical involvement, not the bedrock. One cannot "bracket" the world because one is never outside it.

**Being-in-the-world vs the transcendental ego.** "Being-in-the-world" (*In-der-Welt-sein*) is **one unitary phenomenon** - the hyphens are the doctrine; it resists decomposition into subject + relation + object. Its evidence is the analysis of **equipment**: a hammer is first met as **ready-to-hand** (*Zuhandenheit*), absorbed in an "in-order-to" web (nail-board-house-dwelling), the *worldhood* of the world. Only when it **breaks** does the bare **present-at-hand** (*Vorhandenheit*) object of theoretical staring appear - so the detached ego of theory is a *founded*, deficient mode, not the origin. Against Husserl's constituting ego stands Dasein's thrown, practical disclosedness (*Befindlichkeit*, *Verstehen*, *Rede*), unified as **Care** (*Sorge*).

**Objection, reply, verdict.** Husserlians reply that Heidegger has merely relocated, not answered, the constitution question, and that description still needs *some* methodological purification. But the decisive point stands: if the subject is always already worldly, the reduction cannot reach a presuppositionless residue. Provenance discipline: cite *Being and Time* (1927) by section (worldhood ss.15-18, Care s.41); the work is **unfinished** - never say it "completes" the analysis of Being.

### 3. 2019 Q3(a) · 20 marks

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**Question:** Is Dasein authentic existence for Heidegger? How does he relate temporality with Dasein? Discuss.

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2019 repository ledger.



**Demand decoding:** - correct the premise about Dasein. - explain authenticity. - relate Care and temporality. - evaluate the unfinished project.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 340–400 words in about 18 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

### Timed independent model answer

Dasein is not, by definition, authentic existence. It is the being for whom its own Being is an issue, and it can exist either authentically or inauthentically. "Proximally and for the most part" Dasein is dispersed in das Man, the anonymous "they," through idle talk, curiosity and ambiguity. This falling is structural, not a moral defect. Authenticity is a modification of the same being-in-the-world: the call of conscience summons Dasein from public dispersion, while being-toward-death discloses death as its ownmost, non-relational, certain and indefinite possibility. Anticipatory resoluteness then owns, rather than escapes, thrown existence.

Heidegger relates Dasein to temporality through Care. Care is "ahead-of-itself—already-in—a-world—alongside" entities. Its meaning is ecstatic temporality: the future corresponds to projection and being-toward-death; having-been to thrownness and facticity; and the present to involvement with entities. These ecstases are not three successive moments. They form a unified temporal openness, with the future having priority because anticipation gathers Dasein's thrown possibilities into an owned whole. This gathering also grounds historicity: Dasein inherits possibilities from its having-been and projects them anew rather than merely occupying a point in chronology. Ordinary clock-time, an endless sequence of nows, is derivative from this finite primordial temporality.

Thus authenticity is not Dasein's essence but one way a temporal being can own its possibilities. Authentic temporality is not private escape: resoluteness retrieves inherited possibilities within being-with, while inauthentic temporality levels them into an endless public present. This distinction also explains why authenticity can be episodic rather than a permanently acquired condition. The analysis illuminates finite existence, yet its formal character supplies no substantive moral criterion. Sartre can object that Heidegger does not derive concrete freedom from temporality, while Levinas argues that privileging one's own death neglects responsibility to the Other. These criticisms do not undo the temporal structure, but they expose its ethical incompleteness. Moreover, Being and Time remains unfinished: the promised transition from Dasein's temporality to the meaning of Being as such was not completed. Heidegger therefore establishes temporality as the horizon of Dasein's Care more securely than he establishes it as the horizon of Being generally.

**Measured model-answer words:** 347

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine's exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

### Expanded repair notes:

**Thesis.** No - Dasein is **not** by definition "authentic existence." Authenticity is one *modification* of Dasein's being; Dasein is inauthentic "proximally and for the most part," and Heidegger relates temporality to Dasein by showing that **temporality is the meaning of Care**, the very structure that makes both modes possible.

**Correcting the question.** The trap is in the wording. Dasein (being-there) is the entity whose own Being is an issue for it; its being is **Care** (*Sorge*): "ahead-of-itself - already-in (a world) - alongside (entities)." Falling into **das Man** (the anonymous "they"), through idle talk, curiosity and ambiguity, is *inauthenticity*, and it is a **structural** feature, not a deficiency or moral failing. Authenticity (*Eigentlichkeit*) is the owning of Care through the **call of conscience** and **being-toward-death** (*Sein-zum-Tode*) - death disclosed as ownmost, non-relational, certain and indefinite - issuing in **anticipatory resoluteness** (*vorlaufende Entschlossenheit*).

**Temporality related to Dasein.** The decisive second half: the *meaning* of Care is **temporality** (*Zeitlichkeit*). Dasein exists as three **ecstases** (ek-stasis, "standing out"): the **future** (*Zukunft* - coming toward oneself, projection, being-toward-death), **having-been** (*Gewesenheit* - thrownness, facticity), and the **present** (*Gegenwart* - making-present). These map one-to-one onto Care (ahead-of-itself / already-in / alongside). The **future has primacy**: in running ahead to death Dasein gathers its thrown existence into a **whole** and grounds authentic **historicity**. Ordinary clock-time - the infinite "now-series" - is a *derived, levelled-down* (**vulgar**) form; primordial temporality is ecstatic and finite.

**Objection and reply.** *Being and Time* (1927) is **unfinished** - Division III ("Time and Being") was never published - so the promised move from Dasein's temporality to the meaning of Being as such is not delivered; Heidegger later underwent the "turn" (*Kehre*). Sartre objects that temporality should ground *freedom*, not merely formal ontology; Levinas, that being-toward-death individualises excessively, neglecting the Other's time.

**Verdict.** Dasein is not "authentic existence" but the entity whose being (Care) is **temporal** and which *can* exist authentically by owning its finitude. Authenticity is the futural gathering of a temporal being, not its definition.

## 4. 2019 Q4(c) · 15 marks

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**Question:** How does Sartre look at the problem of freedom of choice and determinism? Explain.

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2019 repository ledger.

**Demand decoding:** - state the freedom thesis. - explain meaning-conferral. - distinguish situation from determinism. - give a qualified verdict.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 250–300 words in about 12 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

### Timed independent model answer

Sartre treats the opposition between freedom and determinism as falsely posed. Determinism treats consciousness as being-in-itself, one caused thing among others. The for-itself, however, is nihilating consciousness: it can distance itself from the given, imagine alternatives and project possibilities. A desire or circumstance becomes a motive only within the meaning that a project confers on it. Since that meaning-conferral already expresses freedom, no motive determines choice before freedom has taken it up.

This does not imply unlimited power. Sartre distinguishes freedom from the range of achievable outcomes. Body, past, class and circumstance constitute facticity; they restrict what can be done, but do not by themselves settle what the situation means or which project will be pursued. Freedom is therefore situated: I cannot choose to fly, but I must still take up the significance of my inability. Hence Sartre's claim that there are "no excuses."

Bad faith shows the practical consequence: a person treats a motive or role as a determining cause in order to conceal the freedom by which it is accepted. Anguish, conversely, is awareness that no prior cause can choose in one's place.

The strongest objection is that coercion, trauma and structural oppression can narrow both action and awareness of alternatives. Early Sartre risks converting agency into an unfalsifiable absolute. His later Critique of Dialectical Reason, with scarcity, seriality and the practico-inert, concedes deeper social conditioning. The defensible conclusion is not that human beings are omnipotent, but that a situation does not acquire practical meaning independently of consciousness's project. This resists mechanical determinism while preserving real constraint.

**Measured model-answer words:** 259

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine's exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

**Expanded repair notes:**

**Thesis.** Sartre treats "freedom versus determinism" as a **false problem**: determinism misunderstands the *pour-soi* by treating it as an *en-soi*, a thing among causes, whereas consciousness is nihilating freedom, so no motive can determine it in advance.

**Doctrine and the pivotal argument.** The *pour-soi* is constituted by **nihilation** (*neantisation*) and transcendence: it stands back from any given, questions it, imagines otherwise, and projects beyond it. The pivot is **meaning-conferral**: a desire, emotion or circumstance becomes a *motive* only through the meaning consciousness freely confers on it - and conferring meaning is itself an act of freedom. Therefore no motive operates *prior to* freedom; determinism's causal chain never reaches the choosing that constitutes its own "causes." Hence "there are no excuses" - motives acquire significance within projects, while passion and situation remain genuine constraints rather than instantly dismissible choices.

**Freedom within situation.** This is not the fantasy that I can do anything. Sartre grants **facticity** ("situation") and insists freedom operates *within* it, not *despite* it: I cannot fly, but I remain free to interpret my inability and to project against it. Freedom is absolute in the *field of meaning*, not in the field of physical possibility. (The slogans "condemned to be free," "man is nothing but what he makes of himself" come from the 1945 lecture *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, published 1946, not from *Being and Nothingness* of 1943 - a precision worth signalling.)

**Objection and reply.** The strongest objection is psychological and social: extreme coercion, mental illness and structural oppression seem to limit not only action but the very *awareness* of alternatives (Merleau-Ponty, the Marxist critique). Sartre's reply is situated freedom, and his later **Critique of Dialectical Reason**

(1960) integrates scarcity, seriality and the "practico-inert," conceding material constraint far more than before - a significant self-revision, not a refutation.

**Verdict.** The radical thesis is unfalsifiable as stated, and Sartre came to qualify it; the defensible residue is not "we are absolutely free" but "no situation's meaning is settled independently of an act of freedom" - which is sufficient to resist thing-like determinism without erasing constraint.

## 5. 2020 Q3(a) · 20 marks

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**Question:** What does Kierkegaard mean by saying "Subjectivity is the truth" in the context of the problem of 'the single individual'?

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2020 repository ledger.

**Demand decoding:** - define subjective truth. - connect the single individual. - guard against relativism. - assess the anti-system claim.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 340–400 words in about 18 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

### Timed independent model answer

By "Subjectivity is the truth" Kierkegaard does **not** mean that truth is whatever the individual feels; he means that for existential and religious truth the decisive thing is the *how* - the mode of appropriation - and that this truth can be lived only by "the single individual" (*den Enkelte*), never by the anonymous crowd or the Hegelian System.

The claim comes from the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* (1846), written under the pseudonym **Johannes Climacus** - cite the pseudonym, as Kierkegaard's own "First and Last Declaration" asks. Its target is Hegel's objective System, which dissolves the existing person into a moment of the universal. Kierkegaard distinguishes the *what* (objective content) from the *how* (the manner of holding it): for logic and mathematics objective truth suffices, but for the truths one must *exist* - ethical and religious truth - "an objective uncertainty held fast in the most passionate inwardness is the truth, the highest truth attainable for an existing individual." Truth here is a matter of infinite personal commitment and risk, not of detached demonstration.

The correlate of subjectivity is *den Enkelte*. "The crowd is untruth" - not because groups are always wrong, but because the crowd enables ethical evasion; responsibility can be borne only by one who stands alone (before God or before the ethical demand). The System can contain everything except the one who builds it: "a logical system is possible; an existential system is impossible."

The standard misreading is that "truth is subjectivity" collapses into relativism. The reply: the doctrine concerns the *mode of appropriation*, not the propositional content; Kierkegaard does not deny objective truth in logic or science, he denies its *sufficiency* for existence. Complementing it, he can even say "subjectivity is *untruth*" - before God the individual, in sin, is in untruth and needs the paradox of faith - which shows the doctrine is not a celebration of arbitrary feeling.

Hegelians charge fideism and elitism (who can achieve such inwardness?). Kierkegaard answers that reason is not *wrong* but *limited* - it cannot deliver what the existing individual needs. Verdict: "truth is subjectivity" is a permanent critique of impersonal system-philosophy, defensible precisely because it is a claim about *how* one must hold existential truth, not a denial that anything is objectively so.

**Measured model-answer words:** 365

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine's exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

**Expanded repair notes:**

**Thesis.** By "Subjectivity is the truth" Kierkegaard does **not** mean that truth is whatever the individual feels; he means that for existential and religious truth the decisive thing is the *how* - the mode of appropriation - and that this truth can be lived only by "the single individual" (*den Enkelte*), never by the anonymous crowd or the Hegelian System.

**Doctrine and evidence.** The claim comes from the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* (1846), written under the pseudonym **Johannes Climacus** - cite the pseudonym, as Kierkegaard's own "First and Last Declaration" asks. Its target is Hegel's objective System, which dissolves the existing person into a moment of the universal. Kierkegaard distinguishes the *what* (objective content) from the *how* (the manner of holding it): for logic and mathematics objective truth suffices, but for the truths one must *exist* - ethical and religious truth - "an objective uncertainty held fast in the most passionate inwardness is the truth, the highest truth attainable for an existing individual." Truth here is a matter of infinite personal commitment and risk, not of detached demonstration.

**The single individual.** The correlate of subjectivity is *den Enkelte*. "The crowd is untruth" - not because groups are always wrong, but because the crowd enables ethical evasion; responsibility can be borne only by one who stands alone (before God or before the ethical demand). The System can contain everything except the one who builds it: "a logical system is possible; an existential system is impossible."

**Guarding against relativism (the marked point).** The standard misreading is that "truth is subjectivity" collapses into relativism. The reply: the doctrine concerns the *mode of appropriation*, not the propositional content; Kierkegaard does not deny objective truth in logic or science, he denies its *sufficiency* for existence. Complementing it, he can even say "subjectivity is *untruth*" - before God the individual, in sin, is in untruth and needs the paradox of faith - which shows the doctrine is not a celebration of arbitrary feeling.

**Objection, reply, verdict.** Hegelians charge fideism and elitism (who can achieve such inwardness?). Kierkegaard answers that reason is not *wrong* but *limited* - it cannot deliver what the existing individual needs. Verdict: "truth is subjectivity" is a permanent critique of impersonal system-philosophy, defensible precisely because it is a claim about *how* one must hold existential truth, not a denial that anything is objectively so.

## 6. 2020 Q4(a) · 20 marks

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**Question:** "You can always make something out of what you have been made into." Critically discuss this statement by Sartre with reference to his views on existentialism.

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2020 repository ledger.

**Demand decoding:** - decode facticity and transcendence. - explain situated freedom. - press structural objections. - grade the quotation.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 340–400 words in about 18 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

### Timed independent model answer

"You can always make something out of what you have been made into" compresses Sartre's whole doctrine of **situated freedom**: "what you have been made into" is **facticity**, "make something out of" is **transcendence**, and the sentence asserts that facticity is always raw material for a free project, never a destiny.

The *pour-soi* is not a thing with a fixed nature but a **project** - it exists by surpassing the given toward chosen ends. Facticity (*facticité*) - body, class, past, the way others have shaped me - is real and inescapable; but it has no fixed *meaning* until freedom confers one. Because I am "**condemned to be free**" (the phrase is from the 1945 lecture *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, published 1946, not from *Being and Nothingness* of 1943), I cannot *not* choose what to make of what has been made of me - even passivity is a choice, usually **bad faith**. Total **responsibility** follows: "there are no excuses," because circumstance supplies the material, never the verdict.

The engine of the claim is that a condition constrains me only through the sense I give it: the same working-class origin can be lived as humiliation, as spur, or as solidarity. So even oppression does not *determine* the response; it sets the situation within which a free response is fashioned. This is why Sartre can say freedom is absolute in the field of meaning while granting that it is not unlimited in the field of action.

The Marxist objection (Merleau-Ponty) is that this underestimates how structural oppression cripples not just action but the *awareness* of alternatives. Yet the statement belongs to Sartre's transitional and mature account of **situated freedom**, developed around *Search for a Method* and *Critique of Dialectical Reason*. By integrating scarcity, seriality and the practico-inert, that account argues that freedom can be deeply *conditioned* without being abolished.

Read as "no situation's meaning is settled independently of praxis," the sentence is defensible and defeats determinism; read as "circumstances never really limit us," it distorts Sartre's mature attempt to reconcile freedom with historical conditioning. The graded position keeps the former and rejects the latter.

**Measured model-answer words:** 347

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine's exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.



**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

**Expanded repair notes:**

**Thesis.** "You can always make something out of what you have been made into" compresses Sartre's whole doctrine of **situated freedom**: "what you have been made into" is **facticity**, "make something out of" is **transcendence**, and the sentence asserts that facticity is always raw material for a free project, never a destiny.

**Doctrine and evidence.** The *pour-soi* is not a thing with a fixed nature but a **project** - it exists by surpassing the given toward chosen ends. Facticity (*facticity*) - body, class, past, the way others have shaped me - is real and inescapable; but it has no fixed *meaning* until freedom confers one. Because I am "**condemned to be free**" (the phrase is from the 1945 lecture *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, published 1946, not from *Being and Nothingness* of 1943), I cannot *not* choose what to make of what has been made of me - even passivity is a choice, usually **bad faith**. Total **responsibility** follows: "there are no excuses," because circumstance supplies the material, never the verdict.

**Analysis - the meaning-conferral core.** The engine of the claim is that a condition constrains me only through the sense I give it: the same working-class origin can be lived as humiliation, as spur, or as solidarity. So even oppression does not *determine* the response; it sets the situation within which a free response is fashioned. This is why Sartre can say freedom is absolute in the field of meaning while granting that it is not unlimited in the field of action.

**Objection and reply (critically discuss).** The Marxist objection (Merleau-Ponty) is that this underestimates how structural oppression cripples not just action but the *awareness* of alternatives. Yet the statement belongs to Sartre's transitional and mature account of **situated freedom**, developed around *Search for a Method* and *Critique of Dialectical Reason*. By integrating scarcity, seriality and the practico-inert, that account argues that freedom can be deeply *conditioned* without being abolished.

**Verdict.** Read as "no situation's meaning is settled independently of praxis," the sentence is defensible and defeats determinism; read as "circumstances never really limit us," it distorts Sartre's mature attempt to reconcile freedom with historical conditioning. The graded position keeps the former and rejects the latter.

## 7. 2021 Q4(b) · 15 marks

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**Question:** "I can always choose, but I ought to know that if I do not choose, I am still choosing". Critically discuss Sartre's conception of choice and responsibility in the light of above statement.

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2021 repository ledger.

**Demand decoding:** - explain non-choice as choice. - derive responsibility. - connect universal implication. - qualify coercion and constraint.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 250–300 words in about 12 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

## Timed independent model answer

Sartre's statement means that choice is inescapable, not that every option is physically available. The for-itself is nihilating consciousness: it cannot coincide with a fixed essence and cannot suspend the freedom through which it projects itself. Deferring, conforming or letting another decide still takes up a stance toward the situation. To present such non-choice as imposed necessity is ordinarily bad faith, a flight from the anguish of freedom.

Responsibility follows because motives and circumstances become reasons within projects that consciousness sustains. Sartre therefore says that there are "no excuses." Responsibility is also wider than private preference: "in choosing myself I choose man." A choice presents an image of human conduct as worth choosing, so anguish registers the weight of this universal implication.

Choice is not an isolated mental event. It is expressed across a continuing project, and even habitual conduct can reaffirm or revise that project. This is why Sartre links freedom to responsibility rather than to momentary whim.

The difficult case is constrained agency. Poverty, coercion, trauma or indoctrination may restrict action and even obscure alternatives; describing every failure to resist as a free choice can become victim-blaming. Sartre's answer is situated freedom: facticity conditions the field without mechanically determining its meaning. His later Critique of Dialectical Reason further recognizes scarcity, seriality and the practico-inert.

The statement is therefore sound as an ontological claim that a self-defining consciousness cannot step outside all choosing. It is less secure as an unqualified moral claim about equal responsibility in unequal situations. Non-choice remains a mode of choice, but the degree and conditions of responsibility require attention to concrete constraint.

**Measured model-answer words:** 267

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine's exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

### Expanded repair notes:

**Thesis.** "I can always choose, but... if I do not choose, I am still choosing" dramatises Sartre's claim that **freedom is inescapable**: because the *pour-soi's* very being is freedom, non-choice is itself a choice - usually a choice in **bad faith** to let others or circumstances decide - and total responsibility follows.

**Doctrine and evidence.** The *pour-soi* is nihilating consciousness; it cannot coincide with itself and cannot suspend its freedom, because freedom is *what it is*, not a property it has. Hence there is no neutral ground "outside" choosing: to defer, to conform, to "wait and see" is to choose to let the situation or the Other decide - a flight from the anguish of freedom, i.e. bad faith (pretending I am not free). This is why "man is **condemned to be free**" - condemned, because he did not choose to exist; free, because once thrown he is inescapably self-defining.

**Analysis - choice and responsibility.** Since every state I am in is *freely sustained*, I bear **total responsibility**: "there are no excuses." Responsibility widens further - "**in choosing myself I choose man**": every choice posits an image of what a human being ought to be, a quasi-Kantian universalisation



that is the source of **anguish's** weight. Choice is thus never merely private; it legislates.

**Objection and reply (critically discuss).** The sharpest objection questions the very distinction the statement rests on: is "choosing not to choose" really different from *being unable* to choose? Structural oppression - poverty, coercion, indoctrination - seems to limit not only action but the awareness of alternatives, so that "you are still choosing" can sound like blaming the victim. Sartre's reply is situated freedom, and his later **Critique of Dialectical Reason** (1960) concedes scarcity, seriality and the practico-inert - a real qualification of the doctrine's early absolutism.

**Verdict.** The statement is true as an account of the *inescapability* of freedom - there is no exit from choosing for a being whose existence is freedom - but its moral use must be tempered by the recognition that situations condition how, and how freely, one chooses. "Condemned to be free" is an ontological structure, not a licence to ignore circumstance.

## 8. 2022 Q2(a) · 20 marks

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**Question:** Provide a critical account of Heidegger's Being-in-the-world and discuss the problem of 'authenticity' in the context of Dasein.

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2022 repository ledger.

**Demand decoding:** - explain unitary being-in-the-world. - develop worldhood and Care. - explain authenticity. - evaluate formal emptiness.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 340–400 words in about 18 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

### Timed independent model answer

Being-in-the-world is Dasein's fundamental constitution, while authenticity is a possible modification within it. The hyphenated expression names one phenomenon, not a self-contained subject later related to an external world. Heidegger supports this claim through worldhood: entities are first encountered as ready-to-hand equipment within an "in-order-to" network—hammer, nail, house, dwelling. Present-at-hand objects emerge derivatively when equipment breaks or is theoretically isolated. Practical involvement therefore precedes the Cartesian division of subject and object.

Dasein's disclosedness comprises attunement, understanding as projection, and discourse. Attunement reveals how Dasein already finds itself disposed; understanding opens possibilities; discourse articulates the intelligible world. These existentialia are unified as Care: being-ahead-of-itself, already-being-in-a-world, and being-alongside entities. Care is not an occasional feeling of concern but the formal unity of projection, thrownness and involvement. Dasein ordinarily exists through das Man, dispersed in idle talk, curiosity and ambiguity. Such falling is structural rather than sinful.

Authenticity does not remove Dasein from everyday being-with. Anxiety disrupts familiar significance; the call of conscience summons Dasein from public dispersion; and being-toward-death discloses death as its ownmost, non-relational, certain and indefinite possibility. In anticipatory resoluteness Dasein owns its

thrown projection instead of receiving its possibilities anonymously.

The problem is that this account is formally empty. It explains how a commitment may be owned but not which commitments deserve endorsement. Nor does authenticity restore an isolated sovereign subject: being-with remains equiprimordial, and inherited possibilities remain factual. A second criticism is methodological: the breakdown analysis may show that practical coping precedes detached inspection without proving that every theoretical relation is merely deficient. Heidegger can reply that founded modes remain valid even when they are not primordial. Adorno's criticism and Heidegger's political record nevertheless make the separation of ontology from ethics philosophically troubling. Levinas further argues that responsibility to the Other should outrank the self-individualization achieved through death. Thus being-in-the-world decisively overcomes spectator metaphysics, whereas authenticity remains illuminating as a structure of owned finitude but insufficient as a moral ideal. Being and Time's unfinished character also limits any claim that the analysis completed the question of Being.

**Measured model-answer words:** 340

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine's exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

**Expanded repair notes:**

**Thesis.** Being-in-the-world is the fundamental constitution of Dasein, and authenticity is a **modification within** that structure, never an escape from it: being-in-the-world is the *what* of Dasein, authenticity the *how*.

**Critical account of being-in-the-world.** "Being-in-the-world" (*In-der-Welt-sein*) is **one unitary phenomenon** whose hyphens dissolve the Cartesian subject/object split - describing Dasein as "a human being located in the world" forfeits the doctrine. Its evidence is **worldhood**: entities are first met as **ready-to-hand** equipment (*Zuhandenheit*) inside an "in-order-to" referential totality (hammer-nail-house-dwelling); the detached **present-at-hand** object (*Vorhandenheit*) of theory appears only when equipment **breaks**, so theoretical cognition is a *founded*, deficient mode. Dasein's disclosedness is structured by the **existentialia** - *Befindlichkeit* (attunement/mood), *Verstehen* (understanding as projection), *Rede* (discourse) - unified as **Care** (*Sorge*): "ahead-of-itself - already-in - alongside."

**The problem of authenticity.** Dasein first exists as **das Man** (the anonymous "they"), dispersed in idle talk, curiosity and ambiguity - **falling** (*Verfallen*), which is *structural*, not a moral fault. **Authenticity** (*Eigentlichkeit*) is reached through the silent **call of conscience** and **being-toward-death** (*Sein-zum-Tode*) - death as ownmost, non-relational, certain, indefinite - issuing in **anticipatory resoluteness**. The marked point: authenticity is **not a moral category**; it is a *formal* modification of everydayness, owning one's thrown projection. It does not take Dasein *out* of the world; it lets Dasein be in-the-world in a way that is *owned* rather than dispersed.

**Objection and reply.** The decisive criticism is that authenticity is **formally empty**: prescribing no content - "own your choices," not *which* choices - it could dignify any resolute commitment ("a Nazi could be authentic"). Adorno's "jargon of authenticity" and Heidegger's own 1933 complicity press this; Levinas

answers with the primacy of the Other over death, Arendt with natality over mortality. Heidegger's defence - fundamental ontology is not ethics - is textually correct but philosophically unsatisfying. Provenance: *Being and Time* (1927) is unfinished; cite by section.

**Verdict.** Being-in-the-world is Heidegger's decisive dissolution of Cartesian dualism; authenticity is its most contestable extension, powerful as ontology and hazardous as ethics precisely because of its deliberate formality.

## 9. 2022 Q4(a) · 20 marks

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**Question:** How does Søren Kierkegaard define the notion of 'subjectivity'? Explain it with reference to three stages of existence as propounded by him.

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2022 repository ledger.

**Demand decoding:** - define subjectivity. - explain three stages. - show qualitative transition. - evaluate faith and reason.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 340–400 words in about 18 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

### Timed independent model answer

For Kierkegaard, subjectivity is not private feeling but the passionate inward appropriation of truths that must be lived. In the Concluding Unscientific Postscript, Johannes Climacus distinguishes the objective "what" from the subjective "how." Logic and factual inquiry require objective standards, but ethical and religious truth demands commitment, risk and transformation by the existing single individual. "Truth is subjectivity" therefore denies the sufficiency of detached knowledge, not the existence of objective truth.

The three stages describe qualitative spheres of existence. The aesthetic life pursues immediacy, novelty and enjoyment; its figures include the seducer and the ironic spectator. Because it avoids binding continuity, its fragmentation issues in boredom and despair. The ethical life chooses continuity through duty, marriage and vocation, represented by Judge William, but also discovers guilt because universal demands cannot be perfectly fulfilled. The religious life relates the individual absolutely to God. In *Fear and Trembling*, Johannes de Silentio presents Abraham's faith through infinite resignation, the double movement and the teleological suspension of the ethical. This does not create a general permission to violate morality; the paradox is singular and cannot be converted into a public rule.

These spheres are neither biological ages nor necessary Hegelian moments. Movement between them requires decision or "the leap"; relapse remains possible, and no objective demonstration compels transition. Subjectivity deepens from aesthetic dispersion, through ethical responsibility, to the risk of faith before God. Pseudonymous authorship matters because Kierkegaard stages these possibilities instead of presenting a single impersonal system.

The objection is fideism: if the religious leap suspends publicly assessable reasons, passionate inwardness may shield arbitrary belief. It also raises a social concern, since emphasis on standing alone can understate the institutions and relationships through which ethical selves are formed. Kierkegaard replies that reason and community are limited rather than worthless: neither can substitute for the individual's responsibility to appropriate a demand. The account therefore explains transition existentially, through transformed

commitment, rather than proving it as a necessary conceptual progression. His view remains a powerful critique of systems that erase first-person existence, but its religious culmination is persuasive only if the leap retains responsible limits.

**Measured model-answer words:** 350

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine's exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

**Expanded repair notes:**

**Thesis.** For Kierkegaard "subjectivity" is not private feeling but **passionate inwardness** - the mode in which an existing individual appropriates existential truth - and the **three stages of existence** (aesthetic, ethical, religious) trace the intensification of that inwardness, joined not by logical transition but by the **leap**.

**Subjectivity defined.** Against Hegel's objective System, Kierkegaard (through the pseudonym **Johannes Climacus**, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, 1846) holds that for the truths one must *exist* the decisive factor is the *how*, not the *what*. "truth is subjectivity" means truth as infinite passionate inwardness, commitment and risk, not detached demonstration. It is **not relativism** - it concerns the mode of appropriation, not a denial of objective (logical, scientific) truth. Its correlate is *den Enkelte*, the single individual; "the crowd is untruth."

**The three stages.** (1) **Aesthetic** - life for enjoyment, immediacy, possibility and irony (the seducer of *Either/Or*, 1843); it dissolves into boredom and **despair**. (2) **Ethical** - the self commits to universal duty, marriage, vocation (Judge William); it discloses guilt, for the earnest self cannot fulfil the moral law. (3) **Religious** - faith before God, the paradox, the absurd; **Abraham** (*Fear and Trembling*, 1843, by **Johannes de Silentio**) is the **knight of faith** who by "**infinite resignation**" and the "**double movement**" performs the **teleological suspension of the ethical** - faith overriding the universal moral law. These are **qualitative spheres**, not chronological phases; one does not mature out of the aesthetic, one **leaps**, and relapse is always possible.

**The leap and the link to subjectivity.** The movement between spheres is decisional, not dialectical - "the leap" (Kierkegaard writes of *Springet*; the fused phrase "**leap of faith**" is the English tradition's, not his term). Subjectivity *is* this intensification: from dispersion (aesthetic) through duty (ethical) to "the absolute relation to the Absolute" (religious).

**Objection, reply, verdict.** Hegelians charge fideism and elitism; Kierkegaard replies that reason is limited, not refuted, and that responsibility requires standing alone. Verdict: the doctrine is a permanent critique of impersonal system-philosophy - subjectivity as the deepening of inwardness across three incommensurable spheres, held together only by the leap.

## 10. 2023 Q1(d) · 10 marks

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**Question:** How does Kierkegaard argue against Hegel's idea of universal spirit in favour of the individual as the essence of spirit? Critically discuss.

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2023 repository ledger.

**Demand decoding:** - state Hegelian target. - defend the existing individual. - show structural contrasts. - qualify the critique.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 150–200 words in about 8 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

### Timed independent model answer

Kierkegaard opposes Hegel's universal Spirit by insisting that spirit exists as the self-relation of the concrete single individual, *den Enkelte*. In Hegel's system the individual appears as a moment within the dialectical self-realization of Geist. Kierkegaard argues that no completed system can contain the existing thinker who must still choose, suffer and die: a logical system may be possible, but an existential system is not.

The contrast is structural. Against mediation he places either/or decision; against necessary sublation, the leap; and against direct systematic exposition, pseudonymous indirect communication. "The crowd is untruth" because absorption into public universality can dissolve personal responsibility. Spirit is therefore not merely an impersonal historical process but the task of becoming a self, ultimately before God.

Hegelians can object that privileging singularity weakens ethical community and rational accountability. Kierkegaard's reply is that responsibility is possible only for an individual who cannot delegate existence to the system. His critique does not refute Hegel's social philosophy, but it exposes what a total standpoint omits: first-person risk and decision. The individual is the essence of spirit in this existential, not metaphysical, sense.

**Measured model-answer words:** 184

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine's exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

#### Expanded repair notes:

**Thesis.** Kierkegaard argues against Hegel's "universal spirit" by insisting that spirit is realised only as the **self-relation of the existing single individual** (*den Enkelte*), which the System can never absorb: the individual is the essence of spirit precisely because he cannot be *sublated* into the universal.

**Doctrine and evidence.** For Hegel, *Geist* comes to itself as **Absolute Spirit**, and the individual is a vanishing moment in a dialectical whole that reconciles all oppositions. Kierkegaard's counter, pressed through the pseudonyms (notably **Climacus**, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, 1846), is structural, not a list of complaints: "a **logical** system is possible; an **existential** system is impossible" - the System can contain everything except the one who builds it, the existing thinker who must still choose, suffer and die. Spirit is not an impersonal cosmic process but the individual's **self-relation** - "the self is a relation that relates itself to itself" (*Anti-Climacus, The Sickness unto Death*, 1849).

**Analysis - the shape of the opposition.** Against Hegel's **both/and** (mediation) Kierkegaard sets **either/or** (decision); against sublation, the **leap**; against the lecture, **indirect communication**. Where Hegel resolves the "Unhappy Consciousness" into a higher unity, Kierkegaard holds that the existing individual's tension with the universal is *irreducible* - it is lived, not thought away. "The crowd is untruth": to be dissolved into the universal (System, public, objective Christianity) is ethical evasion; genuine spirit requires standing alone, ultimately before God.

**Objection and reply.** Hegelians charge that elevating the singular individual over the community undermines ethics and social responsibility, and courts fideism. Kierkegaard replies that only the individual who stands alone can bear responsibility at all, and that reason is *limited*, not refuted - it cannot deliver the truth one must exist. The critique is powerful *because* it is internal to the Hegelian achievement: it strikes exactly where Hegel had located the Unhappy Consciousness and claimed a cure.

**Verdict.** The opposition is genuine but asymmetrical: Kierkegaard exposes what a completed system-view risks losing about first-person existence and does not compete on the ground of system, which he does not want. The individual is the essence of spirit because spirit is a task to be *existed*, never a result to be *systematised*.

## 11. 2023 Q3(c) · 15 marks

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**Question:** "Consciousness is what it is not and is not what it is." In the light of this statement bring out the chief features of Sartre's conception of consciousness.

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2023 repository ledger.

**Demand decoding:** - unpack both clauses. - explain nihilation. - derive freedom and bad faith. - assess coherence.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 250–300 words in about 12 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

### Timed independent model answer

Sartre's formula—consciousness "is what it is not and is not what it is"—expresses the non-self-identity of being-for-itself. Being-in-itself is full, opaque and self-identical: it is what it is. Consciousness, by contrast, is nihilation. It introduces distance into the given by questioning, negating, imagining and projecting possibilities.

Consciousness "is what it is not" because it exists toward possibilities and a future not yet actual. It "is not what it is" because it cannot coincide with its past or present facticity. The waiter is his social role as a fact, yet is not exhausted by it because he can surpass it. This gap is not formal contradiction but the lived structure of pre-reflective self-presence.

Several features follow. Consciousness is intentional rather than a container of representations; it is free because no fixed essence determines its projects; it is temporal because it exceeds the present toward future possibility; and it can fall into bad faith by pretending to be pure facticity or pure transcendence. Its impossible desire is to unite the self-identity of the in-itself with the awareness of the for-itself—the ideal of the in-itself-for-itself or God—hence Sartre's description of humanity as a "useless passion."



The formula unifies Sartre's accounts of nothingness, freedom and self-deception. Its weakness is that radical non-coincidence can make stable character and social determination appear secondary. Read phenomenologically rather than as a denial of logical identity, however, it captures lived consciousness as an open, future-directed project that never becomes a finished thing in the world.

**Measured model-answer words:** 250

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine's exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

**Expanded repair notes:**

**Thesis.** "Consciousness is what it is not and is not what it is" states the **non-self-identity of the *pour-soi***: unlike the *en-soi* (which simply *is* what it is), human consciousness never coincides with itself, and this single formula grounds Sartre's accounts of freedom, bad faith and temporality.

**Doctrine and evidence.** The *en-soi* (being-in-itself) is full, solid, self-identical - "it is what it is." The *pour-soi* (being-for-itself) is consciousness, defined by **nihilation** (*neantisation*): it secretes nothingness, standing back from the given to question, negate and project. The two clauses unpack this: (a) consciousness "**is what it is not**" - it is always *ahead* of itself, defined by possibilities and a future that do not yet exist, so it *is* what it is not-yet; (b) consciousness "**is not what it is**" - it cannot coincide with its facticity/past: the waiter "is" a waiter and simultaneously "is not," because he transcends the role. (Sartre develops this in *Being and Nothingness*, 1943; the popular slogans belong to the 1945 lecture - keep the sources distinct.)

**Analysis - what the formula does.** Because consciousness is non-self-identical, it is **free** (no fixed nature binds it), capable of **bad faith** (it can hold a truth and its denial in one pre-reflective stance, needing no Freudian unconscious), and **temporal** (ecstatically stretched across past-present-future). The perpetual desire of the *pour-soi* is to become *en-soi* while keeping its consciousness - a self-identical yet self-aware being, the *pour-soi-en-soi* or **God** - which is contradictory, so "man is a **useless passion**."

**Objection and reply.** Is "non-self-identity" a genuine insight or a contradiction dressed in phenomenological language (analytic critics)? Sartre's reply is that the formula is descriptive of lived consciousness - the felt gap between what I am and what I take myself to be - not a formal claim about identity; the *datum* is the pre-reflective self-presence that is never coincidence.

**Verdict.** The formula is the key to Sartre's entire system: it makes freedom, bad faith, temporality and the "useless passion" intelligible from a single ontological root - which is exactly why an answer must reach that root, not merely gloss the sentence.

## 12. 2024 Q1(e) · 10 marks

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**Question:** How does Kierkegaard define truth in terms of subjectivity? Critically discuss.

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2024 repository ledger.

**Demand decoding:** - define the how of appropriation. - distinguish objective truth. - name Climacus. - evaluate fideism.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 150–200 words in about 8 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

### Timed independent model answer

Kierkegaard defines existential truth through the subject's mode of appropriation: "an objective uncertainty held fast in the most passionate inwardness is the truth." In the Concluding Unscientific Postscript, the pseudonymous Johannes Climacus contrasts the objective "what" of a proposition with the subjective "how" in which an existing individual commits to it.

The claim does not make factual truth depend on feeling. Logic, science and history retain objective standards. Subjectivity becomes decisive for ethical and religious truth because these must be lived through risk, responsibility and transformation. Faith is the paradigm: demonstrative certainty would remove the risk that gives faith its existential character. The correlate is the single individual, not the anonymous crowd.

The main objection is fideism. Passionate commitment may protect belief from rational criticism. Kierkegaard replies that reason is limited, not worthless, and that "subjectivity is untruth" also places the self under judgment before God. His view is defensible as a thesis about appropriation rather than correspondence: it shows why possessing a true proposition may be existentially inadequate, while not licensing arbitrary belief as truth.

**Measured model-answer words:** 176

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine's exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

### Expanded repair notes:

**Thesis.** Kierkegaard defines existential truth in terms of subjectivity by locating it in the **how** of appropriation rather than the **what** of content: "an objective uncertainty held fast in the most passionate inwardness is the truth" - the highest truth available to an *existing* individual.

**Doctrine and evidence.** The claim is from the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* (1846), by **Johannes Climacus** (cite the pseudonym). For objective disciplines - logic, mathematics, history - objective truth (correspondence, demonstration) is appropriate. But for the truths one must *exist* - ethical and, supremely, religious truth - what matters is the mode in which the individual holds them: with infinite passion, commitment and risk. Faith is the paradigm: to relate with infinite concern to "an objective uncertainty" is a higher truth than to possess a proof, because a proof would abolish the risk that constitutes faith.

**Analysis - guarding the definition.** Three clarifications keep the definition exact. (1) It is **not relativism**: "truth is subjectivity" concerns the *mode of appropriation*, not the propositional content; Kierkegaard does not deny objective truth, he denies its *sufficiency* for existence. (2) Its correlate is *den Enkelte*, the single individual; "the crowd is untruth," because truth so understood cannot be held by a public, only



appropriated by one who stands alone. (3) It is completed by the complementary "**subjectivity is untruth**": before God the individual in sin is *in* untruth and needs the paradox of faith - so subjectivity is not self-congratulation but a task under judgment.

**Objection and reply.** The Hegelian/analytic charge is fideism and irrationalism - the leap abandons rational accountability. Kierkegaard's reply: reason is not *wrong* but *limited*; it cannot deliver what the existing individual needs, and the point of "truth is subjectivity" is to mark that limit, not to license arbitrariness.

**Verdict.** Kierkegaard's definition is a permanent corrective to the reduction of all truth to objective demonstration: for the truths that must be lived, *how* one holds them is itself part of their truth - defensible exactly because it is a thesis about appropriation, not a denial that anything is objectively so.

## 13. 2024 Q4(a) · 20 marks

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**Question:** What do the existentialist thinkers mean by the slogan "existence precedes essence"? How is human existence related to human freedom according to them? Discuss.

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2024 repository ledger.

**Demand decoding:** - explain Sartre's slogan. - differentiate the three thinkers. - connect existence and freedom. - assess responsibility and value.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 340–400 words in about 18 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

### Timed independent model answer

"Existence precedes essence" is **Sartre's** slogan for the reversal of the Western tradition: for human beings there is no pre-given nature or design; man first exists and then defines himself - and because there is no fixed essence, human existence is **radical freedom**. But "the existentialist thinkers" do not share the slogan uniformly, and this must be said.

Sartre's argument (in the 1945 lecture *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, published 1946) runs from atheism: for an artefact - a **paper-knife** - the artisan's concept (essence, design, function) precedes the object's existence. Classical theism made God such an artisan of man, so human nature preceded human beings. Remove God, and the order reverses: **existence precedes essence** - man exists, encounters himself, and only afterward defines himself by his projects. There is no human nature because there is no God to conceive it.

The demand's plural must be handled with care. **Kierkegaard**, a Christian, never used the phrase; his cognate point is that the existing individual cannot be captured by Hegel's essence-System. **Heidegger** can say "the essence of Dasein lies in its existence," yet in the *Letter on Humanism* (1946/47) he **explicitly repudiates** Sartre's formula as a *metaphysical inversion* that stays within the metaphysics it means to escape. So only Sartre owns the slogan in the strict sense; treat "existentialism" as a family resemblance.

If no essence is given, man is "**condemned to be free**" - freedom is not a property but our very being; it is total, inescapable, and attended by **anguish**. **Responsibility** follows: in choosing myself "**I choose man**," positing an image of humanity (quasi-Kantian universalisation). For Heidegger freedom is Dasein's

thrown **projection** upon possibilities (not voluntarism); for Kierkegaard freedom is real but **bounded** - the leap presupposes that one *can* choose.

Critics ask whether ungrounded freedom can generate *values* without collapsing into decisionism; Sartre replies that the engagement of choice generates its own criteria, but the promised ethics of *Being and Nothingness* was never written. Verdict: the doctrine's force is that it makes evasion impossible - every appeal to nature, role or circumstance is itself a choice; its cost is that it struggles to say *why* one project is better than another.

**Measured model-answer words:** 356

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine's exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

**Expanded repair notes:**

**Thesis.** "Existence precedes essence" is **Sartre's** slogan for the reversal of the Western tradition: for human beings there is no pre-given nature or design; man first exists and then defines himself - and because there is no fixed essence, human existence is **radical freedom**. But "the existentialist thinkers" do not share the slogan uniformly, and this must be said.

**The slogan and its argument.** Sartre's argument (in the 1945 lecture *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, published 1946) runs from atheism: for an artefact - a **paper-knife** - the artisan's concept (essence, design, function) precedes the object's existence. Classical theism made God such an artisan of man, so human nature preceded human beings. Remove God, and the order reverses: **existence precedes essence** - man exists, encounters himself, and only afterward defines himself by his projects. There is no human nature because there is no God to conceive it.

**"The existentialist thinkers" - the family, not a school.** The demand's plural must be handled with care. **Kierkegaard**, a Christian, never used the phrase; his cognate point is that the existing individual cannot be captured by Hegel's essence-System. **Heidegger** can say "the essence of Dasein lies in its existence," yet in the *Letter on Humanism* (1946/47) he **explicitly repudiates** Sartre's formula as a *metaphysical inversion* that stays within the metaphysics it means to escape. So only Sartre owns the slogan in the strict sense; treat "existentialism" as a family resemblance.

**Existence related to freedom.** If no essence is given, man is "**condemned to be free**" - freedom is not a property but our very being; it is total, inescapable, and attended by **anguish**. **Responsibility** follows: in choosing myself "**I choose man**," positing an image of humanity (quasi-Kantian universalisation). For Heidegger freedom is Dasein's thrown **projection** upon possibilities (not voluntarism); for Kierkegaard freedom is real but **bounded** - the leap presupposes that one *can* choose.

**Objection, reply, verdict.** Critics ask whether ungrounded freedom can generate *values* without collapsing into decisionism; Sartre replies that the engagement of choice generates its own criteria, but the promised ethics of *Being and Nothingness* was never written. Verdict: the doctrine's force is that it makes evasion impossible - every appeal to nature, role or circumstance is itself a choice; its cost is that it struggles to say *why* one project is better than another.

## 14. 2025 Q1(c) · 10 marks

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**Question:** Explain the difference between being-for-itself and being-in-itself as presented by Sartre.

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2025 repository ledger.

**Demand decoding:** - define en-soi. - define pour-soi. - explain nihilation. - state the impossible synthesis.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 150–200 words in about 8 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

### Timed independent model answer

In *Being and Nothingness* Sartre distinguishes being-in-itself, en-soi, from being-for-itself, pour-soi. The in-itself is full, opaque and self-identical: it simply is what it is. A stone has no distance from itself, no lack and no projected possibilities.

The for-itself is consciousness. Through nihilation it introduces nothingness into being by questioning, negating and projecting beyond the given. It therefore “is what it is not,” because it exists toward unrealized possibilities, and “is not what it is,” because it never coincides completely with its past or social facticity. This non-self-identity grounds freedom, temporality and the possibility of bad faith.

The distinction is ontological, not a simple contrast between matter and mind. Consciousness is always intentional consciousness of being, yet it is not another thing. The for-itself seeks the impossible synthesis of self-identical being and self-aware freedom—the in-itself-for-itself, traditionally called God. Because this ideal is contradictory, Sartre calls humanity a “useless passion.” The contrast thus explains both consciousness’s freedom and its permanent lack of completed essence.

**Measured model-answer words:** 164

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine’s exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer’s declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

### Expanded repair notes:

**Thesis.** The difference between **being-for-itself** (*pour-soi*) and **being-in-itself** (*en-soi*) is the founding ontological dualism of Sartre’s *Being and Nothingness* (1943): the *en-soi* simply *is* what it is, while the *pour-soi* is nihilating consciousness that *is not* what it is and *is* what it is not.

**Being-in-itself (en-soi).** The *en-soi* is being that is **full, solid, self-identical, opaque** and **without consciousness** - “it is what it is.” A stone simply *is*; it has no inside, no distance from itself, no possibility, no lack. It is non-relational and complete, neither active nor passive, neither affirmation nor negation - massive positivity.

**Being-for-itself (pour-soi).** The *pour-soi* is **consciousness**, and its mode of being is **nihilation** (*neantisation*): it introduces nothingness into being by standing back from the given - questioning, negating, imagining, projecting beyond it. Hence the formulas: it **“is what it is not”** (it is ahead of itself,

defined by possibilities and a future that do not yet exist) and **"is not what it is"** (it cannot coincide with its facticity/past - the waiter transcends the role he "is"). The *pour-soi* is **constituted by freedom**; it is lack, distance-from-self, perpetual self-surpassing.

**Analysis - the relation between them.** The two are not "matter" and "mind" (a common trap) but two *ontological* regions. Consciousness is always consciousness *of* the *en-soi* (intentionality), yet it is not itself a thing. The *pour-soi* perpetually desires to become *en-soi* **while keeping its self-awareness** - to be a self-identical *and* self-conscious being, the *pour-soi-en-soi*, which is the traditional idea of **God**. Because that synthesis is contradictory, the desire is doomed: **"man is a useless passion."**

**Verdict.** The distinction is the key to Sartre's system: freedom, bad faith and temporality all follow from the *pour-soi*'s non-self-identity as against the plenitude of the *en-soi*; the impossible longing to fuse the two defines human reality.

## 15. 2026 Q2(c) · 15 marks

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**Question:** Describe Sartre's notion of consciousness as 'nothing'. How is it different from Husserl's notion of consciousness? Discuss.

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2026 repository ledger.

**Demand decoding:** - describe consciousness as nothing. - state shared intentionality. - contrast the ego and constitution. - give a qualified comparison.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 250–300 words in about 12 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

### Timed independent model answer

Sartre calls consciousness "nothing" not because it is unreal, but because it lacks the plenitude and self-identity of being-in-itself. Consciousness is intentional: it exists as consciousness of an object, contains no thing-like contents, and is non-positionally aware of itself. As being-for-itself it nihilates the given, projects possibilities and "is what it is not and is not what it is." Pierre's absence in the café shows how negation can organize experience. Nothingness thus names consciousness's internal distance from being and grounds freedom.

Sartre shares Husserl's intentionality, rejection of consciousness as a container, and recognition of pre-reflective awareness. Their difference concerns the ego and the task of phenomenology. Husserl's transcendental reduction discloses constituting subjectivity: a pure ego with habitualities for which noematic sense and objectivity are constituted. Sartre, especially in *The Transcendence of the Ego*, treats the ego as a transcendent object produced in reflection. The directed act and its object unify consciousness without an inner substantial inhabitant.

The contrast also changes the status of negation. Husserl analyses how meanings and objects are constituted for consciousness; Sartre makes consciousness itself the rupture through which absence, possibility and refusal enter being. Hence his account directly supports an ontology of freedom rather than remaining a transcendental description of constitution.

Yet the opposition should not be exaggerated. Early Husserl also denied finding an ego as an immanent item, while a Husserlian can regard the pure ego as a formal pole rather than a substance. Sartre is best understood as a non-egological radicalization of phenomenology, not as having simply refuted Husserl.

**Measured model-answer words:** 255

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine's exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

**Expanded repair notes:**

Sartre calls consciousness "nothing" not because it is unreal, but because it lacks the plenitude and self-identity of being-in-itself. Consciousness is intentional: it exists as consciousness of an object, has no thing-like contents, and is non-positionally aware of itself. As the for-itself it nihilates the given, projects possibilities and "is what it is not and is not what it is." Pierre's absence in the café illustrates how negation can structure experience. This nothingness grounds freedom.

The comparison with Husserl requires a shared starting point. Both accept intentionality, anti-representationalism and pre-reflective self-awareness. They divide over the status of the ego and the task of phenomenology. Husserl's later transcendental reduction discloses constituting subjectivity: a pure ego with habitualities for which noematic sense and objectivity are constituted. Sartre, especially in *The Transcendence of the Ego*, treats the ego as a transcendent object produced in reflection. The intentional object and the act's directedness unify consciousness without an inner inhabitant.

Sartre therefore turns phenomenological emptiness into ontology: consciousness introduces nothingness and freedom into being. Yet the opposition should not be exaggerated. Early Husserl also denied finding an ego as an immanent item, and a Husserlian can argue that the pure ego is a formal pole, not a hidden substance. Sartre is best read as a non-egological radicalization within phenomenology, not as simply refuting Husserl.

## 16. 2026 Q3(b) · 15 marks

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**Question:** Explain Heidegger's conception of authenticity and inauthenticity as modes of Dasein's being.

**Metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording and marks checked against the verified 2026 repository ledger.

**Demand decoding:** - define both modes. - explain das Man and falling. - explain resoluteness and death. - preserve the non-moral boundary.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 250–300 words in about 12 minutes, including a brief plan and final check.

### Timed independent model answer

For Heidegger, authenticity and inauthenticity are existential modes of Dasein's being, not moral grades assigned to good and bad persons. Dasein is the entity whose Being is at issue and whose basic constitution is being-in-the-world. "Proximally and for the most part" it exists inauthentically through das

Man, the anonymous “one” that levels possibilities through idle talk, curiosity and ambiguity. Falling names this structural absorption in public interpretation; it is neither a theological fall nor a vice.

Authenticity is a modification within everyday being-in-the-world. Anxiety can collapse familiar significance and disclose Dasein's uncanniness. The silent call of conscience recalls it from dispersion without prescribing a moral rule. Being-toward-death then reveals death as its ownmost, non-relational, certain and indefinite possibility. In anticipatory resoluteness Dasein owns its thrown projection and chooses inherited possibilities as its own. Authenticity therefore neither abolishes being-with nor escapes facticity; it changes how they are taken up.

The two modes share the same structure of Care. Inauthenticity levels projection into publicly available possibilities, whereas authenticity retrieves those inherited possibilities through an owned future. Neither condition is permanent, and authenticity cannot become a detached private realm outside language, history or social existence.

The distinction explains conformity without condemning ordinary social existence as wicked. Its weakness is formal emptiness: resoluteness specifies how to choose but not which projects deserve endorsement. Heidegger can answer that fundamental ontology is not ethics, yet the ethical concern remains. Authenticity is thus owned finite existence rather than moral perfection, while inauthenticity is dispersed rather than sinful existence.

**Measured model-answer words:** 251

**Qualification / criticism:** Preserve the doctrine's exact scope, state the strongest objection, and give a graded conclusion rather than an unconditional endorsement.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

**Expanded repair notes:**

For Heidegger, authenticity and inauthenticity are existential modes of Dasein's being, not moral grades assigned to good and bad persons. Dasein is the entity whose Being is at issue and whose basic constitution is being-in-the-world. “Proximally and for the most part” it exists inauthentically through das Man, the anonymous “one” that levels possibilities through idle talk, curiosity and ambiguity. Falling is this structural absorption in public interpretation; it is not a theological fall or a vice.

Authenticity is a modification within everyday being-in-the-world. Anxiety can collapse familiar significance and disclose Dasein's uncanniness and groundlessness. The silent call of conscience recalls Dasein from dispersion without prescribing a moral rule. Being-toward-death then reveals death as its ownmost, non-relational, certain and indefinite possibility. In anticipatory resoluteness Dasein owns its thrown projection and chooses inherited possibilities as its own. Authenticity therefore does not abolish being-with or facticity; it changes how Dasein takes them up.

The distinction is powerful because it explains conformity without treating ordinary social existence as merely sinful. Its weakness is formal emptiness: resoluteness specifies how to choose but not which projects deserve endorsement. Heidegger can reply that fundamental ontology is not ethics, yet Adorno's criticism and Heidegger's political record show why the ethical boundary remains troubling. Thus authenticity is owned finite existence, not moral perfection, while inauthenticity is dispersed rather than wicked existence.

## Original 1 · 10 marks

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**Question:** Distinguish Kierkegaardian anxiety from despair and explain how each bears on selfhood.

**Demand decoding:** Define the central distinction, reconstruct the argument, test it against a strong objection, and end with a qualified verdict.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 150–200 words in about 8 minutes.

### Timed independent model answer

Kierkegaard distinguishes anxiety from despair by locating them at different moments in the formation of selfhood. Anxiety, analysed by Vigilius Haufniensis in *The Concept of Anxiety*, is the “dizziness of freedom” before indeterminate possibility. Unlike fear, it has no determinate object: the self confronts what it may do and the possibility of failure.

Despair, analysed by Anti-Climacus in *The Sickness unto Death*, is a misrelation in the self’s relation to itself and to the power that established it. A person may despair by refusing to be oneself or by defiantly willing to be oneself apart from God. Anxiety therefore accompanies possibility and choice; despair diagnoses a self that fails to become itself.

Both phenomena disclose freedom and are not reducible to clinical moods. The distinction clarifies why selfhood is an achievement rather than a given substance. Its limitation is theological: despair is finally healed through transparent grounding in God, which narrows the account’s secular reach. Pseudonymous attribution preserves the difference between the analyses rather than flattening them into one doctrine.

**Measured model-answer words:** 170

**Qualification / criticism:** The conclusion must distinguish a defensible structural insight from an overextended ethical or metaphysical claim.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer’s declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

## Original 2 · 15 marks

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**Question:** Examine Sartre’s claim that freedom is situated rather than arbitrary.

**Demand decoding:** Define the central distinction, reconstruct the argument, test it against a strong objection, and end with a qualified verdict.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 250–300 words in about 12 minutes.

### Timed independent model answer

Sartre’s freedom is radical because the for-itself never coincides with its facticity, yet it is situated because freedom exists only through a body, past and social world. Facticity is what has been made of me; transcendence is the project through which I make something of it. A motive does not mechanically determine action, since it becomes a reason only within an interpreted project.



Situated freedom therefore differs from arbitrary choice. Consciousness cannot select any physical outcome or erase its history. Coercion, trauma and poverty restrict practical possibilities and may narrow awareness of alternatives. Bad faith appears both when a person treats facticity as destiny and when one imagines transcendence without limits. Responsibility concerns taking up a situation, not magically abolishing it.

Critics rightly argue that early Sartre understates structural power. His Critique of Dialectical Reason responds by incorporating scarcity, seriality and the practico-inert. This development qualifies rather than abandons the claim that situations require interpretation through projects. Sartrean choice is thus meaning-conferring commitment under constraint, answerable for its project and for the image of humanity it presents.

The Look adds an interpersonal dimension: another person can objectify me and alter the field in which I act, but cannot turn consciousness into a finished thing. Likewise, “non-choice” remains a way of taking up the situation, though responsibility varies with available alternatives.

The durable insight is that facticity does not mechanically settle its own significance. The danger is converting this insight into omnipotence or victim-blaming. Freedom is defensible as situated responsibility, not as independence from bodily, historical and social limits.

**Measured model-answer words:** 258

**Qualification / criticism:** The conclusion must distinguish a defensible structural insight from an overextended ethical or metaphysical claim.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

## Original 3 · 20 marks

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**Question:** Compare authenticity in Kierkegaard, Sartre and Heidegger, and assess whether the term names one doctrine.

**Demand decoding:** Define the central distinction, reconstruct the argument, test it against a strong objection, and end with a qualified verdict.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 340–400 words in about 18 minutes.

### Timed independent model answer

Authenticity names a family resemblance rather than one existentialist doctrine. Kierkegaard, Sartre and Heidegger all oppose dispersion in inherited roles, but they ground owned existence in faith, freedom and finitude respectively.

For Kierkegaard, the single individual becomes a self before God. Aesthetic immediacy and ethical universality remain incomplete until religious existence, staged through paradox, infinite resignation and the leap. Authenticity therefore has substantive theological direction, although Kierkegaard does not offer a single technical doctrine under that label.

Sartre removes the divine ground. The for-itself is condemned to situated freedom, and authenticity is best reconstructed as lucidly owning both facticity and transcendence rather than fleeing into bad faith. Yet its positive ethical content remains thin because Being and Nothingness promised, but did not supply, an ethics.

Heidegger's *Eigentlichkeit* is explicitly non-moral. *Dasein* is ordinarily dispersed in *das Man*. Anxiety, the call of conscience and being-toward-death can disclose anticipatory resoluteness, an owned taking-up of thrown possibilities. Authenticity changes how *Dasein* exists with others; it does not abolish everyday being-in-the-world.

The contrasts also concern method. Kierkegaard communicates indirectly through pseudonyms so that the reader must appropriate a possibility. Sartre offers an ontology of the for-itself and a phenomenology of bad faith. Heidegger locates authenticity within the temporal structure of *Care*, where future projection retrieves a thrown having-been in present involvement. These are not merely different vocabularies for the same experience.

The comparison yields serious differences. Kierkegaard faces the charge of fideism, Sartre of voluntarism and Heidegger of formal emptiness. Their shared form is first-person ownership rather than conformity, but their criteria and philosophical purposes diverge. Kierkegaard asks how the self stands before God; Sartre how freedom assumes responsibility without a given essence; Heidegger how finite *Dasein* owns its possibilities within fundamental ontology.

Consequently, authenticity is a useful comparative category only if treated analogically. It names a resistance to anonymous or objectified existence, but not an agreed source of norms or a common method of justification. Calling it one doctrine would erase the theological, ethical and ontological boundaries that make the three accounts philosophically distinct.

**Measured model-answer words:** 341

**Qualification / criticism:** The conclusion must distinguish a defensible structural insight from an overextended ethical or metaphysical claim.

**Coverage check:** The parsed demand audit below verifies the answer's declared limbs; this is a coverage check, not a prediction of examiner marks.

## Original 4 · 10 marks

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**Question:** "Anxiety is the dizziness of freedom." Explain what Kierkegaard means by anxiety and why he distinguishes it from fear.

**Demand decoding:** Distinguish anxiety from fear in kind, explain what objectlessness discloses, connect possibility with freedom, and preserve the pseudonymous attribution.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 150–200 words in about 8 minutes.

### Timed independent model answer

Kierkegaardian anxiety is not intensified fear but an objectless disclosure of possibility. Fear is directed toward a determinate intrawordly threat such as a dog, examination or fall. Anxiety, analysed by Vigilius Haufniensis in *The Concept of Anxiety* (1844), has no determinate object: its object is "a nothing."

Because anxiety is not about an entity, it discloses a structure - "the possibility of being able." This is why Heidegger calls it the "dizziness of freedom." The person at the edge of an abyss is disturbed not only by the drop but by discovering that nothing physically prevents a leap. Anxiety therefore reveals freedom as open possibility and the risk of self-formation.

Anxiety is present even in innocence and is the presupposition, not the mechanical cause, of the qualitative leap through which sin and responsible selfhood become possible. A caused leap would cease to be free.

The distinction is therefore one of kind rather than degree: fear returns the self to a threatening object, while anxiety exposes the self to its own possibility. Translation should be handled carefully because *Angst* is rendered as both "dread" and "anxiety."

**Measured model-answer words:** 184

**Qualification / criticism:** Anxiety discloses a structure of possibility; it is not automatically infallible knowledge or a substitute for psychological explanation.

**Coverage check:** The answer distinguishes fear from anxiety, explains objectlessness, possibility and freedom, and names Heidegger and the 1929 work.

## Original 5 · 10 marks

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**Question:** Explain Heidegger's notion of *das Man* and show why "falling" is not a moral failing.

**Demand decoding:** Define the anonymous "they," identify its everyday modes, explain falling as an existential structure, and preserve the non-moral boundary.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 150–200 words in about 8 minutes.

### Timed independent model answer

Das Man names the impersonal "anyone" through whom everyday norms are expressed: one reads what one reads, judges as one judges and chooses from publicly available possibilities. It is not simply other people. Because being-with is constitutive of Dasein, public interpretation belongs to being-in-the-world rather than being added to an isolated subject.

Heidegger describes this everyday dispersion through idle talk, curiosity and ambiguity. These are deficient modes of disclosure: meanings circulate without appropriation, novelty replaces sustained understanding, and everything appears already accessible. Falling names Dasein's absorption in this world of concern and in the anonymous authority of the "they."

Falling is not a moral or theological fall. Dasein is inauthentic "proximally and for the most part," so dispersion is an existential structure, not a vice for which blame is assigned. Authenticity is therefore a modification of everydayness rather than an escape from society.

Through anxiety, the call of conscience and anticipatory resoluteness, Dasein can own its thrown possibilities. The change concerns how possibilities are appropriated, not whether the person becomes morally good. The account's residual weakness is formal emptiness: owned choice does not itself determine which projects deserve endorsement.

**Measured model-answer words:** 189

**Qualification / criticism:** The non-moral scope protects fundamental ontology from becoming ethics, but it also leaves the content of resolute choice underdetermined.

**Coverage check:** The answer defines *das Man*, names the three everyday modes, explains falling structurally, and distinguishes authenticity from moral improvement.

## Original 6 · 15 marks

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**Question:** Critically examine Sartre's claim that conflict is the original meaning of being-for-others.

**Demand decoding:** Reconstruct the Look and shame, derive conflict from Sartre's subject-object premises, test those premises, and give a graded verdict.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 250–300 words in about 12 minutes.

### Timed independent model answer

Sartre's conflict thesis follows from his account of the Look. In the keyhole scene, absorbed consciousness is suddenly exposed to possible observation. Shame is not an inference from another body; it is the lived recognition that I have become an object for a freedom whose judgement I cannot control. The Other is therefore an indispensable mediator between myself and the outside that I acquire.

Conflict follows because each freedom seeks to recover itself from objectification. Sartre groups the responses into two strategies. Love, language and masochism attempt to assimilate the Other's freedom, but a possessed or compelled freedom cannot provide the recognition sought. Indifference, desire, sadism and hate attempt to transcend or neutralise the Other, but a reduced object cannot confer free recognition. Each strategy defeats its own aim.

This structure explains the line "hell is other people," but Sartre's later clarification matters: the claim does not mean that every relation is poisonous. It describes relations in which another's judgement becomes the fixed medium of self-torment. The characters in *Huis clos* are dead and unable to reopen their projects.

The criticism attacks Sartre's premises rather than merely rejecting his conclusion. Love, trust, care and cooperative action suggest that looking and being looked at need not be mutually exclusive. Levinas further argues that Sartre still approaches the Other from the self's struggle for mastery. Sartre's later group-in-fusion also admits forms of shared agency.

The Look remains a powerful account of exposure to an unchosen perspective. Conflict is original only if subject and object are treated as exclusive positions; once reciprocal recognition is admitted, it becomes one fundamental possibility rather than the universal meaning of being-for-others.

**Measured model-answer words:** 274

**Qualification / criticism:** The decisive objection targets Sartre's exclusivist subject-object premise, not the reality of shame or objectification.

**Coverage check:** The answer reconstructs the Look, both failed strategies, the corrected meaning of the famous line, and the reciprocity objection.

## Original 7 · 15 marks

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**Question:** "Pseudonymity is the formal counterpart of the doctrine that truth is subjectivity." Discuss.

**Demand decoding:** Derive indirect communication from subjective appropriation, explain the pseudonyms as existence-possibilities, and test the method's self-referential cost.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 250–300 words in about 12 minutes.

### Timed independent model answer

The statement is defensible because Kierkegaard's literary form follows from his account of existential truth. Objective results in history or science can be communicated directly without changing the recipient's mode of existence. Ethical and religious truth, however, concerns how a person appropriates a possibility through inwardness, risk and commitment.

Direct communication would turn such truth into information that could be possessed without being lived. Indirect communication therefore withholds a final result and refuses authorial authority so that the reader must choose. Its Socratic model is maieutic: the communicator becomes a vanishing occasion who "deceives into the truth" rather than handing over a doctrine.

Pseudonymity gives this method concrete form. Johannes de Silentio admires faith without claiming to possess it; Johannes Climacus presents himself as not a Christian while asking how one becomes one; Anti-Climacus writes from an ideal Christian standpoint above Kierkegaard's own. Each voice is a personified existence-possibility whose limits matter to interpretation.

The signed Upbuilding Discourses provide the direct pole of this double authorship. In the "First and Last Declaration" appended to the Postscript, Kierkegaard calls himself the pseudonyms' prompter and asks that their statements be attributed to them.

The method creates a genuine problem: if subjective truth cannot be stated directly, the thesis itself appears self-undermining. Kierkegaard's signed Point of View offers retrospective guidance, but its posthumous publication and apologetic purpose prevent it from simply cancelling the pseudonymous distances. Climacus's revocation of the Postscript accepts the self-referential cost. Pseudonymity is therefore not disguise but a self-consuming method designed to prevent existential truth from becoming a transferable system.

**Measured model-answer words:** 260

**Qualification / criticism:** The method protects appropriation but makes Kierkegaard's own settled position difficult to attribute.

**Coverage check:** The answer derives the method, distinguishes major pseudonyms, includes double authorship and the Declaration, and addresses self-reference.

## Original 8 · 20 marks

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**Question:** "Anxiety is not a stronger kind of fear." Examine the role of anxiety in Kierkegaard, Heidegger and Sartre, and assess whether a mood can disclose a philosophical truth.

**Demand decoding:** Establish the difference in kind, compare the three disclosures, distinguish Sartrean anguish from nausea, answer the naturalist objection, and grade the epistemic claim.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 340–400 words in about 18 minutes.

### Timed independent model answer

Fear and anxiety differ in kind rather than degree. Fear discloses a determinate entity as threatening and keeps the subject within an established world of concern. Anxiety has no such object. Since it nevertheless has intelligible content, the existentialists treat it as disclosing a structure rather than an entity.

The comparison rests on a shared phenomenological sequence. Moods disclose a situation before reflective judgement; fear remains tied to one being; anxiety withdraws that object; the withdrawal exposes the background structure that ordinary practical absorption conceals. The three thinkers agree on the sequence but disagree about what the disclosed structure is.

For Kierkegaard, Vigilius Haufniensis in *The Concept of Anxiety* describes anxiety as the "dizziness of freedom." Its object is "a nothing," and what it reveals is possibility, "the possibility of being able." Anxiety is present in innocence and is the presupposition, not the mechanical cause, of the qualitative leap into sin and responsible selfhood.

For Heidegger, anxiety in *Being and Time* section 40 makes the familiar referential world lose significance. That in the face of which and that for which Dasein is anxious are the same: being-in-the-world as such. Anxiety individualises Dasein, discloses uncanniness and frees it for authentic choosing. In "What is Metaphysics?" it also reveals the Nothing, though this later formulation should not replace the existential analytic.

For Sartre, anguish reveals the for-itself's unsupported freedom. On the cliff path, fear concerns falling, while anguish arises when I realise that nothing guarantees I will not throw myself over. The gambler similarly finds yesterday's resolution present but powerless unless it is remade. Anguish must be distinguished from nausea, which discloses the contingency of being-in-itself.

The shared argument is that moods are not private colourings added to a neutral world; they are ways a situation is disclosed. Objectlessness therefore requires explanation. Yet the naturalist can treat anxiety as clinical or neurochemical without granting philosophical privilege.

The existentialist need not claim that anxious persons possess infallible knowledge. A mood may disclose a structural relation - possibility, being-in-the-world or freedom - while remaining corrigible and compatible with causal explanation. Anxiety is philosophically revealing when its form is analysed, but the three thinkers' conclusions must not be merged into one theory.

**Measured model-answer words:** 365

**Qualification / criticism:** Mood-disclosure is a fallible phenomenological claim and does not refute clinical or naturalistic accounts.

**Coverage check:** The answer gives the shared argument, differentiates all three thinkers, separates anguish from nausea, and answers the naturalist objection.

## Original 9 · 20 marks

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**Question:** Existentialism has been charged with subjectivism, pessimism and social abstraction. Examine these charges with reference to Kierkegaard, Sartre and Heidegger.

**Demand decoding:** Split the family label, test each charge thinker by thinker, distinguish misdescription from residual weakness, and concede the strongest surviving objection.

**Word/time guidance:** Write 340–400 words in about 18 minutes.

### Timed independent model answer

The three charges cannot be answered on behalf of a single existentialist school. Kierkegaard died before the label became current, Heidegger denied it in the Letter on Humanism, and Sartre alone accepted and defined it. Each objection therefore requires three different tests.

This family-label warning is methodologically important. Kierkegaard's question concerns becoming a self before God, Sartre's concerns freedom without a divine blueprint, and Heidegger's concerns the Being of Dasein. A criticism that moves unchanged across those projects risks attacking a retrospective category rather than any philosopher's actual argument.

The charge of subjectivism largely misfires. Kierkegaard's "truth is subjectivity" concerns passionate appropriation in ethical and religious existence, not the denial of objective truth; its complement, "subjectivity is untruth," blocks relativism. Sartrean choice is not private preference because it accepts responsibility and presents an image of humanity. Heidegger is conducting fundamental ontology, while his criticism of das Man opposes reliance on received opinion.

Pessimism is also usually a semantic mistake. Anxiety, despair, death and nothingness are technical structures rather than reports that every life is miserable. Kierkegaardian despair may be unfelt; Heideggerian being-toward-death individualises possibility rather than recommending morbidity; Sartrean anguish registers freedom rather than hopelessness.

Social abstraction is the strongest charge. Early Sartre under-describes racialised, gendered and material constraint. De Beauvoir, Fanon and Marxist criticism expose this weakness, and Sartre's later Critique of Dialectical Reason introduces scarcity, seriality and the practico-inert. Heidegger makes being-with constitutive, but authenticity remains formally empty, a problem sharpened by his political record and Adorno's criticism. Kierkegaard preserves individual responsibility but offers a thin account of institutions and community.

The charge also differs internally. Sartre attempts a later conceptual repair, whereas Heidegger can reply that fundamental ontology was never intended as social ethics. Kierkegaard can insist that institutions cannot substitute for appropriation. Those replies clarify scope, but neither scope-limitation supplies the missing account of domination, collective action or institutional reform.

The available replies are partial. Situated freedom denies that facticity mechanically determines meaning; being-with denies an originally isolated Dasein; the single individual resists absorption into systems and crowds. None fully supplies a social theory.



Subjectivism and pessimism are therefore mostly misdescriptions produced by ignoring technical vocabulary. Social abstraction remains a genuine residue: later Sartre repairs part of it, while Heideggerian and Kierkegaardian resources are insufficiently institutional. A defensible verdict preserves existentialism's account of responsibility and finitude while conceding its uneven treatment of structural power.

**Measured model-answer words:** 398

**Qualification / criticism:** The strongest answer concedes the social-theory deficit instead of dissolving every criticism through vocabulary.

**Coverage check:** The answer separates the three projects, rules on all three charges, uses later Sartre, and gives a residual rather than total defence.

## Self-evaluation grid

| Criterion       | 0         | 1              | 2                                   |
|-----------------|-----------|----------------|-------------------------------------|
| Demand coverage | missed    | partial        | every limb answered                 |
| Attribution     | conflated | mostly correct | thinker/work precise                |
| Argument        | list      | some links     | reconstructed mechanism             |
| Criticism       | absent    | named          | objection, reply and residual limit |
| Verdict         | absent    | generic        | graded and demand-specific          |

Stop handwriting if pain, numbness, tingling, swelling or weakness increases; resume only when comfortable.

## Inbound obligations from Topic 09

- WP-2018-Q4A-EPOCHE-HEIDEGGER — Topic 10 is the primary owner of 2018 Q4(a). The answer defines Husserlian epoché as suspension of the existence-posit, then explains that Heidegger rejects a worldless spectator-subject because Dasein is always already being-in-the-world. The Husserlian premise remains Topic 09's bounded contribution.
- WP-2026-Q2C-SARTRE-HUSSERL-CONSCIOUSNESS — Topic 10 is the primary owner of 2026 Q2(c). The answer establishes Sartre's non-egological consciousness as nothing and compares it with Husserl's intentional and constituting transcendental subjectivity. Topic 09 supplies the Husserlian half without owning Sartre's position.

Neither obligation permits Topic 09 to claim primary ownership, Heideggerian being-in-the-world to be treated as Husserl's doctrine, or Sartrean nothingness to be reduced to Husserlian epoché.